MIDDLE EAST AND TERRORISM

SINCE THE END of World War II the Middle East has been both a flashpoint for conventional conflicts and a breeding ground for terrorism. Much of the impulse for this has derived from the particular political and historical conditions in the region—questions of land, oil, nationhood, and religion. The other great catalyst for war has been the relations between Iraq and the wider world. The Iran-Iraq War led to around one million deaths in the 1980s, and generated many of the political conditions that led to the Gulf War of 1990–91. Following the terrorist attacks on New York in September 2001 and the subsequent US-led "War on Terror," tensions in the Middle East remained high. The invasion of Taliban-controlled Afghanistan and the ongoing conflict in Iraq mean that foreign troops continue to be deployed throughout the region. In all these conflicts, the waters of the Gulf have been a critical battle zone. Controlling the shipping lanes through this vital oil-producing region remains essential, hence the United States Navy still maintains a forceful presence in the region, guarding against terrorist and conventional foe alike.

OPERATION PRAYING MANTIS

PRAYING MANTIS



Date April 18, 1988
Forces Americans: 10 ships; Iranians: 13 ships
Losses Americans: 1 helicopter; Iranians: 3 speedboats, 1 frigate, 2 oil platforms damaged

Location
Persian Gulf

On April 14, 1988, the US Perry class frigate *Samuel B. Roberts* was patrolling the Gulf waters off Qatar when it spotted three naval mines in the water. In its attempt to evade the devices the ship hit a fourth mine that detonated, injuring 10 and blowing open the side of the hull. The mines were identified from their serial numbers as Iranian. With the United States committed to keeping the Gulf navigable for Kuwaiti oil tankers, a strong US reaction was inevitable.

US RETALIATION

The American response was codenamed Operation Praying Mantis. Commanded by Rear-Admiral Anthony A. Less, Praying Mantis had as its main objective the destruction of Iranian oil platforms in the Gulf by amphibiously deployed US Marine and SEAL units. As a by-product, it was hoped that this would draw Iranian warships into the Gulf waters, where they could be destroyed by the US surface vessels plus carrier aircraft flying from the *Enterprise*.

The attack was launched on April 18 when two units of destroyers, frigates, and amphibious ships assaulted the Sassan and Sirri oil platforms. Resistance was first crushed by naval gunfire, then Marines were dropped by helicopter onto the platforms, where they placed demolition charges and left.

The Iranian navy responded in force. It sent out a group of armed Boghammar speedboats, though three of these were quickly sunk by bombing runs from US A-6E Intruder aircraft. A Kaman-class fast attack craft was similarly despatched by Harpoon missiles and naval gunfire. Two Iranian F-4 fighters made a run at the guided-missile cruiser *Wainwright*, but were scared off when *Wainwright* replied with Standard surface-to-air missiles. The Iranians now committed their most significant naval vessels—the frigates *Sahand* and *Sabalan*. *Sahand* went first, but was intercepted by aircraft and destroyed by three Harpoon missiles and four laser-guided bombs. The *Sabalan* was crippled by a single bomb dropped down its funnel; the US aircraft and ships then left it dead in the water.

Operation Praying Mantis, the largest US military engagement since the end of World War II, dealt a major blow to the Iranian navy and to Iranian pride. US losses amounted to two men killed in a helicopter crash, an unusually light toll for such a high-risk mission.



Sassan oil platform
US Marines inspect an anti-aircraft gun on one of the two Iranian oil platforms destroyed during Operation Praying Mantis.

WITNESS TO WAR

COMMANDER BUD LANGSTON

A-6 INTRUDER PILOT DURING THE ATTACK ON IRANIAN FRIGATE SABALAN

OPERATION PRAYING MANTIS

*"My bombardier-navigator was looking at this (Iranian ship) on our **forward looking infrared** and it certainly matched the silhouette that we're looking for. So we made a **high speed dive right down** to on top of the water a couple miles behind the ship and as we approached **the ship opened fire on us and that gave a pretty good idea it wasn't a friendly** … she clearly had the number of the Sabalan and tracers were going over the canopy from its **anti-aircraft guns and shoulder fired weapons** and rounds were going off all around the canopy."*

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

MARK 45 GUN

Although naval cannon have been largely superceded by guided missiles as the primary anti-ship and anti-aircraft defense on modern warships, the fully-automated Mark 45 proves that there is still a role for a fast and accurate lightweight naval gun. First developed in the 1960s by BAE Systems, the 5-in Mark 45 has gone on to become the principal lightweight naval gun of the US Navy and several other navies worldwide. Aboard US ships the Mark 45 is controlled by the Mark 86 Gun Fire Control System or the Mark 160 Gun Computing System, both of which give rapid automated target acquisition and fire control. The gun is fed by an automatic loading system that can fuel automatic rates of fire of up to 20 rounds per minute, and the gun can engage naval, land, or even (with air burst shells) aerial targets. Although most Mark 45s have a range of about 15 miles (24 km), the latest Mod 4 version has a greater velocity and, with advanced rocket-assisted, satellite-guided ammunition, a range of up to 71 miles (115 km). The qualities of the Mark 45 will doubtless keep it in service for many more years to come.



Lightweight naval artillery
The guided-missile destroyer USS *Forrest Sherman* fires a rocket-assisted 5-in shell from her Mk-45 Mod-4 gun during exercises in the Atlantic.